The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, rose to over $90 a barrel, despite the **International Energy Agency** announcing that it would release 400m barrels of oil from its reserves. The global forecaster's 32 members agreed to release record amounts of oil in a bid to stabilise prices. The blockade of the Strait of Hormuz has curtailed global oil supply by roughly 20m barrels a day.

Earlier the **Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps**, the regime's security forces, who declared Hormuz closed, warned countries to "get ready for oil to be $200 a barrel". The group reportedly struck three commercial ships along the waterway on Wednesday. Meanwhile **Iran's** president said America and Israel could only end the war if they recognise Iran's rights, guarantee against future aggression and pay reparations.

Donald Trump, however, insisted that the war will end "soon" as there was "practically nothing left to target", in comments to Axios, a news site. Separately, the Pentagon said it was investigating a strike on a girls' school in Iran, in which 175 people were killed, following reports that it was targeted as a result of outdated American intelligence data. Mr Trump has previously blamed Iran.

America's annual **inflation** rate was 2.4% in February. The rate, which remains unchanged from January and is the lowest since 2021, was in line with forecasts. The data was gathered before the global surge in energy prices, which would only begin to appear in next month's data—but may inform the Federal Reserve's rate decision next week.

Britain's government released hundreds of files related to **Peter Mandelson**, its former ambassador to America who was recalled over his links with Jeffrey Epstein, a dead sex offender. The files include warnings about the appointment's "reputational risk"; a senior adviser is quoted as having called the process "weirdly rushed". The revelations raise further questions about the judgment of Sir Keir Starmer, threatening his premiership.

As global drugmakers claw for a share of **India's** fast-growing obesity market, the country's drug regulator cautioned companies against "misleading" advertisements. In India weight-loss drugs are meant to be prescribed by a pharmacist and the country does not allow prescription products to be advertised. The regulator warned that even a promotion "under the pretext of disease awareness", would be considered a "surrogate advertisement".

Around 18,000 people were evacuated from **Dresden** after a bomb from the second world war was uncovered by construction workers in the German city. Police said the weapon has been defused. Last year the discovery of wartime bombs in the city also led to evacuations. During the war mass bombing raids by the Allied forces devastated the city and destroyed the *Frauenkirche.*

Figure of the day: 56, the total number of ethnicities in China, of which 55 are getting squashed. Read our story.

Photograph: Getty Images

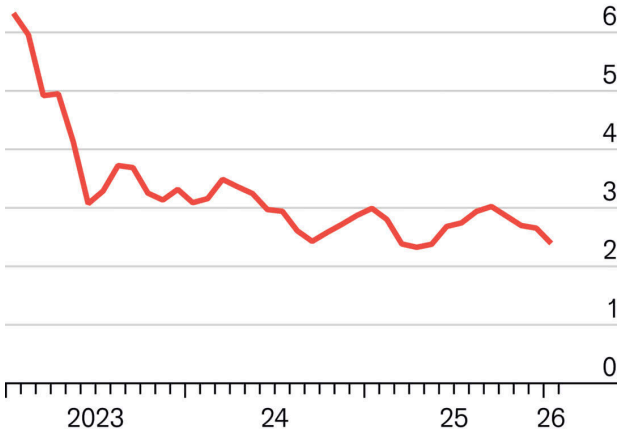
War in Iran torpedoes America's progress on inflation

For a few months American inflation appeared to be cooling. By the start of 2026 Donald Trump's tariffs had in large part passed through to higher prices. Meanwhile, high interest rates took some heat out of the jobs market. The "affordability crisis" became a story of already-high prices, rather than still-rising ones.

But Mr Trump's attack on Iran triggered retaliatory strikes that blocked the Strait of Hormuz, a vital shipping lane. The benchmark West Texas Intermediate oil price surged by about 75%, peaking at around $120 per barrel before falling to around $85—still a quarter higher than before the war. Inflation figures for February, to be published on Wednesday, will not reflect the effects of the conflict. Forecasters think the annual price rise was 2.4%, above the Federal Reserve's 2% target but not by much. The real question will be what the numbers for March show and how much damage Operation "Epic Fury" has done to America's progress in reducing inflation.

False dawn?

United States, consumer price index, % increase on a year earlier



Sources: BLS; BEA

Photograph: Kenny Holston/The New York Times/Redux/eyevine

Anthropic takes the Trump administration to court

A legal battle over who controls the world's most important technology is proceeding rapidly. On Tuesday representatives from Anthropic, an artificial-intelligence lab, urged a federal court to fast-track its lawsuits against America's Department of War, which the company says could cost it billions in revenue this year.

The spat has been ugly. On February 26th Anthropic refused to alter its contract with the Pentagon over fears its technology might be used for mass surveillance of Americans or in fully autonomous weapons. A week later Anthropic became the first American company to be designated a supply-chain risk by the government, barring its models from defence projects. On Monday, Anthropic said that it was suing the DOW. The company has some sympathy among Silicon Valley's AI developers: more than 30 employees from Google and OpenAI, two rival AI giants, have filed an "amicus" brief in support. The first hearing has been brought forward to March 24th.

Photograph: Jan Woitas/dpa

Europe’s plan to avert an energy crisis

On Wednesday Ursula von der Leyen, the president of the European Commission, is taking part in a parliamentary debate about the war in the Gulf and its consequences. Among them are the sharp swings in oil prices and markets instability. Ms von der Leyen has called it a “stark reminder” of the vulnerabilities created by Europe’s dependence on fossil fuels.

Some European governments are weighing tax cuts on fuel; others want to cut environmental measures. (Viktor Orban, Hungary’s prime minister and an ally of the Kremlin, has called on the EU to lift its sanctions on Russian energy.) The arrival of spring and less demand for heating—plus measures taken to diversify supply after Russia invaded Ukraine in 2022—mean the continent is unlikely to run out of gas, but Europeans may still feel some financial pain. Leaders of the EU’s 27 member states will meet next week to discuss how to prevent a sharp rise in bills from hobbling its still-fragile economy.

Photograph: Bridgeman Images

The memory of Fukushima

On Wednesday Japan observes the 15th anniversary of the deadly earthquake that triggered the worst nuclear disaster since Chernobyl. A tsunami killed almost 20,000 people across the north of the country and triggered a meltdown at a nuclear power plant in Fukushima. The nuclear disaster displaced about 160,000 people from the surrounding area. With trust in nuclear power shattered, Japan closed all 54 of its remaining reactors.

Public opinion has since shifted. In 2013, a poll by *Asahi Shimbun*, a newspaper, showed that 58% of respondents were opposed to restarting the plants, while only 28% supported it; by 2023, support outnumbered opposition for the first time, as energy bills soared during the Ukraine war.

Wednesday's commemoration will therefore be held amid a striking policy reversal. Having pledged to reduce nuclear dependence after Fukushima, Japan's newly empowered government is now pursuing "maximum utilisation". In February TEPCO—the operator responsible for the Fukushima disaster—restarted the world's largest power station, on Japan's west coast.

Photograph: Reuters

The Norwegian underdog of European football

The 16 clubs that remain in the Champions League are a roll call of Europe’s elite squads. They include six from the money-soaked Premier League in Britain, three from Spain, Germany’s Bayern Munich and France’s Paris Saint-Germain, the defending champions.

Yet the name that stands out is Bodo/Glimt of Norway, whose 8,200-capacity home stadium is just inside the Arctic Circle. The club has won Norway’s Eliteserien league in four of the past six years. The minnow is now going after Europe’s big fish. Last season Bodo/Glimt reached the semi-finals of the Europa League, a level down from the Champions League. So far in the Champions League, they have defeated Atletico Madrid and Manchester City, two heavyweights, and knocked out Inter Milan, last year’s finalists, in the play-off round. If they win the first leg against Sporting Lisbon, one of the weaker teams in the tournament, on Wednesday, they could continue their improbable run into the quarter finals.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily Quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Wednesday: What was the biggest hit by DNCE, a rock band whose lead singer was Joe Jonas?

Tuesday: Which William Somerset Maugham novel features a cholera epidemic in China?

Fear cannot be banished, but it can be calm and without panic; it can be mitigated by reason and evaluation.

Vannevar Bush